

How to Divide Your Prayer Time

Turn to John 16. I will not be very long, though when I say that I always do it with the best intentions.

The further you get into this, the better it gets. The more you learn about Him, fellowship with Him, and spend time in His presence, the better it gets. There is nothing any of us does that is taxing enough to keep us from entering into His presence.

One of the most powerful things we have in prayer is the name of Jesus. When you say, "Father, I ask this in Jesus' name," there is power in that name because of what the name represents. It represents victory and the finished work of the cross.

When you use His name, you are using the name that represents the price He paid so you could have the answer to your prayer. You are asking in the name of the accomplished work of the cross.

The prayer of petition is one of the most powerful prayers there is.

If I knew now what I did not know before entering ministry, and if I had only a limited amount of time to spend in God's presence, I would divide that time into three parts: praying in tongues, worship, and confession.

If I had five good hours to give Him, I would divide those hours among those three.

Now that I understand confession better from Ephesians 5, I link confession with worship. Worship brings the presence of God to your soul. It magnifies His presence in your spirit until you become more aware of spiritual things than natural things.

Worship makes confession enjoyable. It keeps confession from becoming dry breath and dust. When worship brings His presence, confession becomes fellowship.

God ministered to me that this message has come to maturity and must be turned loose. He intends to take it outside this camp. A group of people will take this message and press it through.

If I were you, I would become stronger than ever. Be relentless, because God is going to pour something out on us.

In the day of reward, you will be intensely glad that you remained faithful when you could see no evidence and feel no evidence. You had no outward assurance except His Word, yet you stayed faithful until the fruit came. Many will get on board when they can see it with their eyes. Thank God for the work they do then, but there is a greater reward for those who received it in the Spirit before they saw it.

Praying in tongues brings long-term change. When you begin steadily praying, you invest six months, then a year, and incredible change begins to come to the real problem.

Jesus said:

Whosoever shall say unto this mountain, Be thou removed, and be thou cast into the sea; and shall not doubt in his heart...

Whether the mountain goes depends on whether you doubt in your heart. The real reason the mountain does not move is not outside you; it is what is happening in the heart.

It is easy to justify failure and blame other things. One of the greatest signs of weakness is to look for excuses instead of facing the responsibility of change. Coming face to face with responsibility is one of the first steps into change.

When you choose a lifestyle of praying in tongues, you choose long-term change. You choose to deal with the things that keep the mountain from moving over a lifetime.

There is a difference between assaulting a temporary problem and letting God perfect your entire life. Temporary problems can be addressed through petition and confession. Permanent change comes through letting Him deal with you at the root.

If a problem has come and you only have a short time to address it, praying in tongues is still powerful, but it deals mostly with edification and long-term change. For immediate problems, take the Word to your soul.

Walk around the table and speak the Word over the problem. If you are willing to speak God's Word over what needs to change hundreds of times, even that decision carries faith. You are not going to spend that much time with God and remain unconcerned about the other things in your life that need to change.

Any direction you take into prayer will benefit you.

When I link worship and confession, I begin by worshiping God until His anointing and presence come. Then I speak His Word and revolve back into worship. His presence stays on me, and confession becomes fellowship.

I may say:

"I worship You. I praise You. I glorify You. I magnify You, Jesus. I love You. I adore You."

Three of my favorite words are "I love You."

But it is not merely saying the words. It is collecting my whole soul, not letting it wander down the street solving yesterday's problems, and pouring my mind, will, intellect, and emotions into that simple statement: "I love You, Jesus."

When my mind wanders, I go get it back. I learned not to disrespect my King by offering lip service while my mind is somewhere else. I would rather say, "I love You," with all of me than invent a flowery array of words without my heart.

What pleases Him is worship with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength.

John 16 says:

Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth...

He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you.

The Holy Spirit does not speak of Himself. His ministry is to glorify Jesus and lead us into His presence. When you worship with the adoration of your whole soul, the Holy Spirit magnifies Jesus.

You can tell when He comes. His presence is amplified in your soul. Your senses detect Him. The atmosphere is charged. Half an hour earlier worship may have felt like a chore, but when His presence comes, you do not want to stop.

Sometimes He graces us in a service and sweeps through like that. But those strong manifestations do not have to be rare bones thrown to hungry people. We can learn to enter His presence by pouring the whole soul into worship.

When you come to worship Him, let Him know you are there. It is not necessarily how loud you are; it is how much of your soul you pour into each statement.

The Holy Spirit brings me into the presence of Jesus. Then Jesus brings me into the presence of the Father.

John 16 continues:

In that day ye shall ask me nothing. Verily, verily, I say unto you, Whatsoever ye shall ask the Father in my name, he will give it you.

Hitherto have ye asked nothing in my name: ask, and ye shall receive, that your joy may be full.

Jesus was speaking of the day of the new covenant. Until then, the disciples ran to Jesus. But He said that in that day they would ask the Father in His name.

Then He says:

For the Father himself loveth you, because ye have loved me, and have believed that I came out from God.

The Father Himself loves you because you love Jesus. He loves the human race so deeply that He put the answer into the finished work of Christ. He took blessing out of arbitrary uncertainty and placed it in the hands of every person who comes through the cross.

When you come into His presence holding the name of Jesus and ask, you can believe He will answer.

I call petition my confession because after I first present it, I continue to speak it as confession.

God already knows your petition before you bring it. Matthew 6 says the Father knows what you need before you ask, and then Jesus teaches us to pray:

Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name...

That prayer gives the prerequisites of petition: worship, consecration to His will, daily bread, forgiveness, and deliverance from evil.

If someone lives rebelliously and only wants to speak a new car into existence, he might as well fold the petition back up. God wants, "Hallowed be Thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done." Then comes daily bread, and even the car needed to go get it.

I want to know Him. I want the spiritual standing of what Jesus did: He incurred my debt as surely as He bore my sin, sickness, pain, unrest, torment, and fear.

The substitution and identification of Jesus goes on and on.

He bore my sin and made me righteous. He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains. The chastisement of my peace was laid on Him. He refused to open His mouth in His own defense before Pilate so that, when the devil puts me on trial for what Jesus delivered me from, I can open my mouth and speak the wisdom He did not speak for Himself.

Every one of these is a position in the Spirit that we must be transformed to.

The standing of wealth is also spiritual. As I worship and confess what Jesus did, I thank Him that by grace He took my poverty and gave me His standing. He incurred my debt. There is nothing I will ever do for the kingdom of God that He has not incurred the debt for.

When that spiritual force began rising in me, I felt incredibly wealthy. I saw opportunity everywhere. It was not natural imagination; it was the standing He gave me by grace rising up in my spirit.

When that standing becomes established, it will not only make millions for you, it will give millions through you. Giving is born out of being rich in that standing. Giving does not create the standing; it manifests it.

It will pay you to spend time with God.

The Father loves you because you love Jesus. God is so deeply in love with humanity that it took two members of the Godhead to undo what Adam and Satan did: Jesus to become humanity and shed His blood, and the Holy Spirit to come and do the work.

The Father is not God the Destroyer. He is God the Redeemer. He is always working for your good.

Because you love Jesus, the One who restored you to fellowship with the Father, the Father loves you even more for loving the One who brought you back to Him.

So when you enter His presence in that name and ask, believe Him.

If you believe, you will enter into worship and fellowship, giving extended glory and praise because He has heard you. If you do not believe, you probably will not do that.

After years of ministry, and after studying the book of John, the heart of the matter is this: if you are born again, the path leads into loving people.

If you are going the other direction, into hatred, that is not the evidence of the new birth.

One of the highest places God can bring you is a place where you will not hurt people. I am not talking about correction, instruction, or righteous exhortation. I am talking about the vindication people feel over the destruction of someone else.

Jesus taught about forgiveness and offense in Matthew 18. He began with the question, "Who is greatest in the kingdom?" and ended by saying that the greatest place of respect belongs to the person who forgives every brother his trespasses from the heart.

Heaven has little respect for hypocrisy: holding a place of honor before people while privately being something else. Heaven sees both.

Soon you will be calling the lost, and you will be handling the most powerful thing in the universe: His Word.

Jesus said:

Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.

Everything temporary will burn. The kingdoms men build for themselves will pass. But every soul sent to heaven, every act of mercy, every hour of prayer, and every dollar invested in the kingdom is on record.

Paul said there is a day when the secrets of men's hearts will be judged according to the gospel. I would be about assimilating the Word of God. I would find out what He wants from me.

When you speak His Word, God is speaking through your mouth. Pick someone lost, put the Word in your mouth, and watch God track that person down. Ask Him to let you know what is happening, and someone will begin to tell you that person is changing.

Stand up.